

Lankan Women

Posted originally on the [Archive of Our Own](http://archiveofourown.org/works/56974807) at <http://archiveofourown.org/works/56974807>.

Rating:	Mature
Archive Warning:	Graphic Depictions Of Violence
Category:	Gen
Fandoms:	Ramayana - Valmiki , Hecuba - Euripides
Characters:	Mandodari (Ramayana) , Vibhishana (Ramayana) , Hanuman (Hindu Religions & Lore) , Sita (Ramayana) , Lakshmana (Ramayana) , Sugreeva (Ramayana) , Indrajit Meghnad (Ramayana)
Additional Tags:	References to Ancient Greek Religion & Lore , Alternate Universe - Ancient Greek Religion & Lore Fusion , Tragedy , Theatre , Ancient History , India , Bitterness , Revenge , Screenplay/Script Format
Language:	English
Stats:	Published: 2024-06-28 Completed: 2024-07-06 Words: 11,539 Chapters: 5/5

Lankan Women

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Summary

Homer's Iliad ends with a great city destroyed, and the Greeks, who themselves have lost the greatest of their heroes, ready to finally sail home. Euripides continues from here by telling the stories of the vanquished: the stories of the women of Troy, now left as slaves to be taken to Greece.

Hecuba tells how Polyxena daughter of Priam, a paragon of virtue and courage, has to sacrifice herself to Achilles' ghost, and how Hecuba, Priam's widow, takes her revenge on a former friend who betrayed her son. Lankan Women tells the same story from the perspective of Mandodari Ravana's widow, with Sita (who enters the flames after her husband rejects her) taking the place of the equally virtuous Polyxena, and Meghanada Mandodari's son taking the place of Polydorus in Euripides. My purpose with Lankan Women is to start a conversation between Valmiki and Euripides, to see if I could make it work.

Euripides makes quite a few changes to events from the Iliad to make Hecuba work. I have made corresponding changes to the Ramayana to make Lankan Women work. These changes I include in a note below. For the Ramayana I take the southern version where Sita is the daughter of Ravana and Mandodari.

Notes

Euripides has made a few changes to the Homeric version of events. In Homer:

- Polydorus is not Hecuba's son
- Polydorus is a man of fighting age, not a boy
- Polydorus dies fighting at the walls of Troy, he is not sent away to Thrace
- Polymestor does not kill Hecuba's son
- Helen does not tell Hecuba of Odysseus spying on Troy
- Hecuba does not save Odysseus' life
- Polyxena does not appear, and Achilles' ghost does not demand her sacrifice
- Polymestor does not warn Agamemnon about his death

I have made corresponding changes to events from the Ramayana. According to Valmiki:

- Vibheeshana has a happy ending as King of Lanka
- indrajit is a man of fighting age, not a boy
- Indrajit dies in battle with Lakshman, Mandodari does not think she has sent him away safely
- Vibheeshana is not present at Indrajit's yagna

- Sita does not tell Mandodari of Hanuman spying on Lanka
- Mandodari does not save Hanuman's life
- Rama does not order Sita into the fire; although it is his behaviour which drives her into it
- Lakshman is not warned about his death

A note on stage directions: Euripides' plays as I have used them tend to come with minimal stage directions, either because they were not included in the ancient originals or because they have been lost over time. The play will therefore be mostly dialogue.

Act I: Mandodari Loses A Daughter

Lankan Women

To the memory of Lanka and Troy

Characters

The ghost of **Indrajit**, son of Mandodari and Ravana

Mandodari, widow of Ravana, Queen of Lanka

Sita, daughter of Mandodari and Ravana

Hanuman, an Indian general

Lakshman, an Indian general and companion to Rama

An **Attendant**, an old rakshasi, servant to Mandodari

Sugriva, an Indian commander, King of Kishkindha, second to Rama

Vibheeshana, brother of Ravana who switched sides during the battle

Chorus of captive Lankan women

The play is set on the field outside the walls of Lanka, after the battle over the city and the death of Ravana. The stage building represents the ruin of what was once a sage's hermitage outside the walls. A lingam crowned with faded flowers stands to the right.

Act I

*The ghost of **Indrajit** appears above the stage building.*

Indrajit. I have left the Gates of Hades where the dead dwell in darkness and come to this place, having taken leave from the Lord of the Dead. My name is Meghanada, also called Indrajit for I once defeated the Father of the Gods, and I am the son of Mandodari, daughter of Mayaa, and of Ravana. Among all Ravana's children I was the most powerful, second only to Ravana himself.

When our City was attacked by Rama and his army of Forest folk, I held the western gate against their onslaught. But our enemies were frenzied by the power of a god, and the Fates had decreed my father's death. And so we were beaten back further and further, until finally I went down to our City's sacred cave at the shore of the eastern sea to sacrifice, and so win back the gods' favour.

By my side was Vibheeshana my uncle, a wise sage and seer known for his virtue and his piety. I took him to preside over my sacrifice, hoping that his godliness would turn the tide of Fate; but Vibheeshana betrayed me, had betrayed us all long ago. He had told our enemies all our secrets; so that when I came with him to the sacred cave, I found a hero of Rama's army there, waiting for me.

Long and hard we struggled; but the gods were on my enemy's side, and my own uncle fought to destroy me. And so I fell upon the altar, my own blood offered for sacrifice; while my treacherous uncle and the hero went off in triumph, certain of Lanka's destruction.

My body they left there in that cavern, prey to the birds and the wolves. There is no one to weep over me, no one to build my pyre and hold my funeral games. And so I have left my empty body and flit about above my dear mother Mandodari. This is now the third day on which I have hovered here – and all that time my miserable mother has been near by the walls of fallen Lanka after leaving our dear City.

And for three days now, the army of Ayodhya has been sitting idle in Lankan fields, their chariots at rest. For Rama, son of Dasaratha, held back the whole expedition as they turned their reins for home. He is demanding that my sister Sita, whom he had taken to wife before she returned to her father's house, burn herself on a pyre for the sake of his own honour, his own purity. For Rama feels tainted by Sita's having lived with Ravana, even though the earth and the sky themselves testify that she was never unfaithful to her husband.

And Rama's demand will be met. He will not be denied this gift by men who love him, though it may pain them to do it. No, my sister's Fate is leading her to her death this day. My mother will see the corpses of both of her children, myself and the unhappy Sita. O my mother, a palace was once your home and now you have seen the day of slavery. Your sorrows are as great now as was your prosperity then! The gods must be balancing out your former happiness with your destruction.

*The ghost of **Indrajit** goes out.*

Mandodari is led on by captive Lankan rakshasis.

Mandodari. O darkness of the night, o day's bright radiance! Why am I roused like this by terrifying phantoms of the night? O sovereign Earth, mother of black-winged dreams, I hurl from myself these black visions, my dreams about my son who remains safely in Lanka, and about Sita, my beloved daughter. Yes, how terrifying the vision I saw! O Lord of the Underworld, keep my boy safe! Now he is the sole anchor of my house.

But some new disaster lies in store, a fresh song of sorrow for sorrowful women. For this is my fear, the bleak vision I saw in the night: that Rama of Ayodhya raised his voice upon the battlefield, and demanded for his honour's sake the fiery death of one of us hard-suffering Lankan women. O turn aside this fate, you gods, from my daughter!

Enter the Chorus of Lankan rakshasis.

Chorus. Mandodari! I have slipped away in haste from my captors in their camp. But I have not come to make your sufferings lighter. No, I am weighed down with the burden of my sorrows! For at a full assembly of our enemies it was said they decided to make your daughter enter the flames of her own funeral pyre. Rama, that great Prince, appeared in his shining armour given him by the gods themselves, and held back his army. These were the words he cried aloud:

“Where are you setting out to, people of the Forest? Do you expect me to take back without protest a fallen woman as my wife? How shall I rule my city with her by my side? How shall I ever win the respect of my people?

“No. Let a pyre be made, a great hot fire, beside Ravana's, and let Sita pass into the flames. Let her burn for her impurity, if impure she is.”

A mighty quarrel surged and crashed, with two opinions splitting the army. All were struck with horror at this sudden change in their Prince; but some remained loyal, deciding that Rama's command must be obeyed, while others decided the opposite. The passions roused were nearly equal on both sides – until Vayu's son, that cunning courtier of the people, persuaded the army not to betray their Prince and their God for a woman's sake.

And he is on his way here this very moment, to tear your daughter from your arms. So go to the temples, Mandodari, go to the altars, throw yourself as a suppliant before Lakshman's knees, cry out to the gods in Heaven and to those in the Underworld. For either your prayers and Sita's virtue will keep your child alive, or you must see your daughter burned to ashes on this day.

Mandodari. What child have I left? What city? Ravana is gone. Lanka is gone, a home to me no longer. You have destroyed me, o women of Lanka. My daughter, my daughter, come out of the house and hear what I have to say!

Enter Sita from the inner rooms of the hermitage.

Sita. Mother, what happened? Why are you shouting so?

Mandodari (*crying*). Oh, my daughter!

Sita. Something terrible must be about to happen. Why else such lamentation?

Mandodari. I cry for your life, o Sita!

Sita. Then tell me, mother! What more could be added to your sorrows?

Mandodari (*crying*). O Sita, child gained and now so cruelly lost!

Sita. Mother, what is it?

Mandodari. Sita my daughter, Rama your husband is calling for you to immolate yourself, burn yourself upon a pyre built by his hands, built by his pride.

Sita. O mother, you victim of terrible sufferings, woman of a wretched fate! No longer shall I comfort you; instead, you shall see me burned to ashes, scattered in the wind. For I know my fate. I know I cannot escape this summons. I weep for you, mother; but for my own life, I shed not a tear. My life was destined for tragedy; and in dying I have met with the happier fate.

Chorus. Mandodari, look! Here comes Hanuman, striding towards us.

Hanuman enters the ruined hermitage.

Hanuman. Lady, I think you know already the decision Rama has made regarding his wife, Sita. I will reaffirm it here: a pyre stands prepared, and Sita is to atone for her stay in your husband's house by burning herself upon its flames.

Lady, I am as shocked by this as you are, believe me. But I cannot disobey my Prince. You know what you have to do. Do not make me tear her away from you by force. Rather, recognize how powerless you are, how your sins overwhelm you, how your husband's evil and opposition to God have brought you to this place.

In my view it is sensible, even amid misfortune, to show good judgement.

Mandodari. Evil, you say? Ravana's evil... I will not deny his lust, his pride. But what devotees to God, the Mahadev, we all were! And now it seems He seeks only to make me suffer agonies piled on agonies. Yet even a slave may ask of her master, unless her questions be impudent. And so it seems only right to me that, now that you have had your say, I ask you some things in return.

Hanuman. Of course, Lady. Ask away. I do not begrudge you the time.

Mandodari. Do you remember when you came into Lanka as a spy, to look for Sita? You crept across the gardens and along the passageways of the women's palace, only a little monkey, desperate not to be seen by Lanka's strong guards.

Hanuman. I remember. It was harrowing to my core.

Mandodari. Do you remember how Sita recognized you, and told only me?

Hanuman. I recollect that I came into great danger.

Mandodari. And you touched my knees in humility, a suppliant to a Queen?

Hanuman. Yes; I clasped you so tightly my hands grew numb.

Mandodari. So, tell me what you said then.

Hanuman (*with a wry smile*). All the arguments I could think up. I wanted to survive.

Mandodari. Did I not keep your secret then? Did I not keep you safe, let you return to your Prince on that other shore, even when you turned on my husband, even when you lit our City on fire and burned a third of Lanka to ashes?

Hanuman. Yes, Lady. You did.

Mandodari. Then are you not degraded by this scheme of yours? You admit that I treated you honourably, you who came to my City as an enemy; and yet you show me no gratitude. You came to me in supplication, touched my hand and knees and chin, as you yourself admit.

Now I touch your hand and your chin in return, and I ask you to pay back my old favour to you. I beg you: do not tear my daughter from my arms. Do not kill her. We have dead bodies enough; the fields of Lanka run red with rakshasa blood. This girl is my only delight. In her I forget my sorrows. She is more than my daughter: she is my City, my guide, my soul.

It is wrong to use power wantonly. For you may have power now; but do you think you will always be powerful? One I was a Queen, and Lanka was the greatest City in the world; now I am a slave, and my City is ashes. Pity me, dear friend. Go back to your army and advise them not to carry out Rama's decision. For it offends Virtue itself, to shed innocent blood.

Hanuman. Mandodari, learn a lesson and do not let your passions run away with you, to regard a man who treats you well in the middle of a battlefield as your enemy. Because you have treated me well, I am ready to keep you safe. I mean it; I shall give a safe conduct to you and your women. You may go to any place you desire, and you shall come to no harm.

But I shall not disobey my Prince. Your daughter must enter the flames of her pyre, and I will not leave without her. You ask me not to take her on account of your great sufferings. But recognize that Sita belongs to Rama by right of marriage, more than she does to you. As for your sorrows, do you think yourself the only widow of this war? On our side, too, we have many aged widows and old men, and young brides too, who weep over sons, husbands,

bridegrooms, now lost forever to the blood-soaked fields of Lanka. You must endure your sorrow, as they do.

Chorus. Do you see, Mandodari? In war, there is no pity for the vanquished.

Mandodari. O Sita, my daughter, you see how useless my words are; all my pleading thrown to the wind. But perhaps he'll listen to you, since you are young and innocent. If you fall in supplication here at Hanuman's knee and beg him for your life, explain to him why this is murder, this is wrong, perhaps his heart will be moved by your plea where mine was fruitless.

Sita. I see you, Hanuman, turning away from me so I won't grasp your knees as my mother did. Do not be afraid. I will not beg for my life. I will not burden your heart with turning away a suppliant whose plea you so wish to grant, but cannot.

Yes, I shall follow you, not merely through necessity but because I want to enter the flames. For what life, what happiness, is left to me outside the fire? By force, against my will, I was taken to this City; I remained chaste and faithful at great cost to myself, for so many moons; and I could find no peace even in my mother's house, because for my sake a great war was fought, for my sake this whole land has been drowned in blood. And now even my husband, who waged war for love of me, now spurns me, calls me tainted and impure.

Mother, I beg you: do not degrade yourself further. Do not try to stop them, do not beg for my life. For I go now to the flames, and I go willingly. Take me off, Hanuman, take me to the pyre that stands prepared for me.

Mandodari. You have spoken noble words, my daughter, but your nobility brings me sorrow. If Rama wishes to avenge himself for your stay with Ravana, and if you, Hanuman, want to avoid the charge of ingratitude, do this: let me burn on that pyre instead of Sita. I married Ravana of my own free will. I was Queen of Lanka, and I stood at my husband's side as he pursued war with the Prince of Ayodhya. If any woman of Lanka must burn for Ravana's sins, it is I, not Sita.

Hanuman. Your death would mean nothing, Lady. It is not a mere sacrifice Rama asks for, in which one victim can substitute for another. It is his wife's impurity that pains him; this is a sacrifice only Sita can bring.

Mandodari. Then at least let me die along with my daughter. Let your Prince's honour receive a double portion of the blood he seeks.

Hanuman. My Lady, please do not add more blood to this ghastly ordeal. One death is bad enough. If only we did not have to go through with this, if only I never needed to ask!

Mandodari. No. I must die with Sita. I will not live without her.

Hanuman. Why? I'm not aware that anyone here is in a position to dictate to me.

Mandodari. I won't let go of her, whatever you say! I'll cling to her like the vine clings to the tree.

Hanuman. No – that is, if you would obey those wiser than yourself.

Mandodari (*clinging to Sita*): I'll never let go of her!

Hanuman. And I shall not leave here without her.

Sita. Do as I tell you, mother. Don't resist. Do you want to be flung to the ground by these monkeys, manhandled by bears and men? You deserve better than that. It is not proper. No, mother, give me your hand for one last time, and say your farewells to me. You are listening to my last words.

(*To Hanuman*) As for you, son of Vayu: be gentle with a mother's passion. Surely you understand the love she feels, the loss at having found her daughter and now losing her again? Don't be harsh with her; show her mercy.

(*To Mandodari*) Mother, what message shall I take from you to the realms of the dead, to your people, your mother, your poor husband?

Mandodari. Tell them I am the most wretched of all women.

Sita. Farewell, mother.

Mandodari. Others fare well. It's not my destiny.

Sita. Give my regards to Meghanada my brother.

Mandodari. If he's alive. I no longer have any confidence.

Sita. You must believe he is. Do not lose hope, mother! For even these calamities will pass.

Mandodari. I wonder that, my daughter. I fear I am already dead, I have no more life to look forward to.

Sita. Hanuman, put your mantle round my head and lead me off. Let my mother see me no longer; for her weeping is melting my heart, and my farewells are melting hers. Light of day! I can invoke your name, but my share in your brightness lasts no longer than my journey to my husband's feet, where the flames await me.

Hanuman starts to lead Sita off.

Mandodari. Please don't leave me without my child! Please, Sita, do not obey this ghastly summons, run, run away with me!

Chorus. Unhappy woman, all is over for you. As for us: breeze, ocean breeze, where will you lead us, carried on a stony bridge across the surging waves? Where will you take us in our misery? To whose house shall we go, as slaves or as suppliants? Will it be to the banks of wide rivers of Ayodhya, or among the swinging root bridges of Kishkindha? We, who once were handmaidens to a Queen, shall we become slaves in those foreign lands?

We all weep for our children, for our parents, for our City, which smoulders with smoke as it lies in ruins, mastered by monkeys and bears and the power of a god.

Act II: The Burning Of Sita

Chapter Summary

Sugriva arrives to tell Mandodari of what happened to her daughter. Like Polyxena, Sita faced her death proudly, knowing her own innocence, looking everyone in the eye; and she put all the heroes and all the men to shame.

Sugriva enters the ruined hermitage.

Sugriva. Where can I find Mandodari, you rakshasis, the woman who was once Queen of Lanka?

Chorus. She is right at your feet, lying on the ground wrapped in blankets.

Sugriva (*shocked*). What am I to say? This war was meant to be virtuous; the victory of good over evil, of dharma over adharma. But is this justice, this old woman lying here in the dust? Was this not the Queen of Lanka, the greatest City in the world? Was she not the wife of Ravana, a man so blessed by fortune and penance? And now her city has been destroyed, her husband is dead, and she herself has been reduced to little more than a rag lying upon the ground.

I am an old man, and have precious little time left in this world; but even so, I pray that I may die before I meet with the shame of such a fate. Stand up, wretched woman!

Mandodari (*on the floor, turned away from him*). Who are you? Why do you disturb my grief, whoever you are?

Sugriva. It is I, Sugriva. You know who I am.

Mandodari (*rising*). O dear friend, have Rama and his army decided to slaughter me on Sita's pyre as well? Such welcome news! Let's make all the haste we can. Lead the way, old man!

Sugriva. Calm yourself, woman. You're not dying today. I've come to fetch you so that you may perform the last rites for your daughter. The Princes of Kosala and their host have sent me.

Mandodari. What are you saying? Are you not here to take me to my death, but only to bring me more bad news? O what sorrow – you'll kill her and make me watch you do it. Tell me, how do you plan to finish her off, old man? Will you show her respect? Or will you tackle the terrible business by slaughtering her like an animal?

Sugriva (*weeping*). We may be monkeys, woman, but do you think we are mindless beasts? Do you think I take pleasure in this? Do you think I and all my people were not struck with horror at hearing our Prince, who had been so gentle, so loving, violently denounce the innocent woman for whose sake we destroyed your City? Do you think I did not want to stop him, or run away in terror and disgust?

I'll tell you what I saw there on the field. The whole host was assembled there before the pyre prepared for the burning of your girl. Some young men lit it, and the wind blew the flames into a blazing fire. Our Prince averted his eyes from Sita, so disgusted he was by the taint he imagined in her, he refused to touch her, even to look at her. And I was nearby, I saw it all.

Picked young men selected from among the warriors attended, to hold down your girl if she struggled. But Sita needed no force to face her death. Her head held high in pride, she looked openly at each one of us. How I shrank in shame when she looked at me! But I could do nothing.

When she came to Rama, he gave her one icy look, then turned away from her. And he said, "Do not delude yourself into thinking that I came here for you. You are a stain on our family and on all womankind. I cannot bear to even look at you, polluted as you are. No man of honour can take home a woman who has lived in his enemy's house for as long as you have. Your life is nothing to me. Your duty to me, and to all the brave men who fought and died on the fields of Lanka, is to enter the flames on this your funeral pyre, and to burn away your tainted life."

That was what he said. We all knew she was innocent; but what could we do? We could not betray our Prince. Then Rama spoke not a word more to her, and signaled the young men to lay hold of her and drag her to her death. But when Sita saw this, she motioned them away. She said, "Men of my husband's, you who have sacked my mother's City, I am happy to die. Let no one lay a hand on me. I shall offer my life with good courage. Leave me free when you kill me, so I can die a free woman and no one's slave or captive! Whatever my husband believes of me, I know I have lived with untainted virtue. It would shame me to enter among the dead bound as one guilty of crime."

We all shouted our approval at her great courage, and Lakshman told the young men to step away from her. Then she continued, "Rama, you boast of your great honour, how you come from a royal house. Some men even call you the incarnation of a God. But you are just common, base as any other man. What honour is there in putting a woman to shame, driving her to her death on a battlefield upon which so many have already lost their lives, all for the sake of your own base suspicion?

"I cannot bear the accusation that I am tainted. Rama tells me he cares nothing for my life. What else have I to live for, then? My father is dead, my mother is shamed and broken, their City is destroyed; and now the man I thought of as my husband, to whom I have stayed faithful all these years, has shamed me in front of everyone, as though I were a common harlot. I choose to go to my death. My place is at the heart of this fire you have all so dutifully prepared for my destruction."

She walked into the fire without the slightest hesitation, without so much as a backward glance, her head held high and still looking proudly at us all. The flames blazed up far above

her head and engulfed her, and we saw her no more.

However bravely we may have fought in this dreadful war, whatever glory we may have won, Sita's courage and devotion put us all to shame. As I say this about your poor, dead daughter, I see that you have the best children and the unhappiest fortune of all women.

Chorus. There is no escape from the tragedies which afflict our City. How great Ravana's sins must have been, to cause so much suffering.

Mandodari. O my daughter, there are so many woes and I do not know which one to turn to! One moment I think of the death of my dear husband; the next I am afflicted by the destruction of my City and the blood still flowing across Lanka's fields. And now, dear Sita, I cannot erase your suffering from my mind. I must mourn you.

But the story of your nobility has finally set a limit to my sorrow. Isn't it strange? Good soil can sometimes produce a bad crop, while poor soil may grow good olives if it gets a single good season. But among men, the bad are always bad, and those with a good nature are always good, even under the greatest misfortune. But nothing is to be gained by speculating on suffering.

(To **Sugriva**): You must take this message to your army: no one must touch my daughter's ashes. The mob must be kept away from her. Men can be a terror to women at the best of times. In a vast army, their blood still up from their recent victory, they are impossible to control. My daughter was pure in body and spirit; I would not wish even her ashes sullied.

(To her **attendant**): And you, my old servant, go to the temples of our ruined city and find me an urn of sacred water, if any is left. I wish to perform last rites for my daughter's spirit. A paltry ceremony it will be: only her old mother there to attend her, no father, no priest, no temple; not at all what she deserves. But what else am I to do?

O house of Ravana, Palace of Many Rooms, we were once so happy and now we have come to nothing. We have been stripped of our former pride, cast down by monkeys and bears. So why do we mortals swell with conceit, one of us over the wealth of his house, the other over his honour and glory? Wealth and honour are nothing. The only man or woman who can be called happy, is one who leads a simple life, and dies without having met anything bad from day to day.

The attendant goes out to the sacred cavern by the seashore. Mandodari retreats to the inner rooms of the hermitage.

Chorus. For us was fated disaster when first an envious old woman corrupted a young Queen's heart, and a faithful wife followed her husband into the dark Forest. For there in the Forest she caught my Lord's eye; and ever since troubles and torments circle us round. From one man's folly came evil for all, with disaster for others, too. And the rivalry was settled here, settled with war, with blood, and with the ruin of our house.

Act III - Murder And Betrayal

Chapter Summary

Queen Mandodari, already mourning the death of her daughter Sita, now discovers the corpse of Meghanada her son as well. She concludes that Vibheeshana, her husband's brother who betrayed his people by choosing Rama's side in the war, killed him, and has an exchange with Lakshman in which she hopes to gain the opportunity to plot her revenge.

The image of Indrajit performing his yagna at a stone altar in a sacred cave by the seashore and being surprised and killed comes from the archaeological record of Crete, where a cave was found containing what looked like a scene of human sacrifice interrupted by the eruption of Santorini. Like Lanka, Crete had been unable to turn away its disastrous fate.

*The **attendant** re-enters with companions carrying the veiled corpse of **Indrajit**.*

Attendant. Women, where is Mandodari?

Chorus. What do you want now? Will you never rest, you awful woman? Will your bad news never end?

Attendant. My words are for Mandodari alone, not you. And if I am a bringer of bad news, I can hardly be blamed for that in the midst of all this calamity.

Chorus. Look, there she is, coming out of the inner rooms. Right on time for your message.

***Mandodari** re-enters the stage from the inner rooms.*

Attendant (*crying*). How I weep for you, my mistress. You have been destroyed. Children, husband, City – all gone.

Mandodari. Keep quiet if you have nothing else to say. You are telling me nothing new. But what have you brought? I sent you to fetch holy water from the shrines in the City; don't tell me you've taken Sita's charred bones from her pyre and brought them here to me!

Attendant (*to herself*). She knows nothing. She still thinks it's only Sita who has died.

Mandodari. Well, speak up! Who else could it be?

Attendant. Mistress, you raise your voice to me, but you do not mourn yet for the one who lies here dead. Let's uncover this corpse, shall we? Let's see if the sight of it does not dash your last remaining hopes.

*She uncovers **Indrajit's** corpse.*

Mandodari. But this is my son – dead! How can this be? Wasn't he supposed to be in the secret cave, our holy sanctuary beside the sea, performing a sacrifice for our sake? Wasn't Vibheeshana supposed to protect him, to aid him there? All is over for me now – I draw breath, but I no longer live.

Chorus. Have you taken it in then, poor woman? Are you still in your senses enough to understand what has happened to you?

Mandodari (*to herself*). I cannot believe what I see. This cannot have happened. By what blow of fate did you die, poor child? What man killed you, you who put fear into the hearts of gods?

Attendant. I don't know. I came upon him as I entered the sacred cavern, looking for water.

Mandodari. Had he been dragged and left there, or had he fallen there by spear or sword?

Attendant. I found him in a pool of blood, but of the weapon that struck him down there was no sign.

Mandodari. Now I understand the vision I saw in my sleep, the evil dream I had about you. O my child, the only son I had left, no longer alive in the light of the sun.

Chorus. Who killed him then? Did your dream tell you that, too?

Mandodari. It was my husband's own brother, the man whom we all thought virtuous and wise, but who proved vile and foolish. All this time you were a traitor to us, dear brother of my husband; and only now do I learn of it, like an evil sent from an avenging demon.

Chorus. What do you mean? Why would Vibheeshana kill your son? Did Rama and Lakshman pay him in gold to do it – but surely he is above such base seduction?

Mandodari. I cannot find the words for it. It is a deed without a name, beyond amazement. It is unholy. Where is the sanctity of our temples now? Where is just dealing, where is love, among families? You accursed man, look what you've done to him! Look how you have butchered this boy's flesh, hacking his limbs with your sword. For all your talk of virtue and good, there was no pity in you.

Chorus. You poor woman, whatever power it is that presses so heavily upon you only increases your suffering without respite. But look, I see the grand figure of Lakshman approaching – let's be quiet now, friends. Who knows what he'll do to us otherwise.

*Lakshman enters the ruined hermitage. Quickly the women cover the corpse of **Indrajit**.*

Lakshman. Mandodari, why are you so slow to offer last rites to your daughter's spirit? Sugriva made us swear that none of our number should lay a hand upon her pyre, and we haven't. We left her alone, we touched nothing. But you are taking your time, and that surprises me. So I have come to fetch you. For in our camp at least things have been well managed – if anything at all can be called good about this whole sordid situation.

(With a start) But whose is this dead body I see by the entrance? Was he one of your people?

Mandodari *(turning away and speaking to herself)*. Wretched woman – yes, I now speak to myself like this, my grief entitles me – what shall I do? Should I fall here at Lakshman's knees, debase myself before him and my women, or should I continue to suffer in silence?

Lakshman. What are you doing, turning your back on me? Look at me, woman, and tell me what happened. Who is this?

Mandodari *(still to herself)*. But what if he were to think less of me, regard me as some sort of fallen woman who throws herself at the feet of strange men? Or what if he sees me only as an asuri, an enemy of his Prince and his God? It would add even more to my sorrows.

Lakshman. I'm not a prophet. I cannot search out your intentions unless you tell me.

Mandodari *(still to herself)*. Or am I judging his feelings too harshly? Perhaps he is not ill-disposed to me.

Lakshman. Is it that you don't want to tell me what is going on? Very well then, we are of one mind. This whole business is a sordid mess. After what happened with Sita, I'm beginning to wonder myself if this entire war was a mistake. You don't want to tell me who this is? Fine, I don't want to hear it either.

Mandodari *(still to herself)*. I cannot avenge my children without this man's help. O, why do I keep turning the matter over and over in my mind? I must summon up my courage, whether I succeed or fail.

*(Kneeling before **Lakshman**)* Lakshman, I hold your knees and beg you as a humble suppliant.

Lakshman. What do you want? Are you asking to leave this place? You are free to go; no one will harm you.

Mandodari. No, I'm not asking for that.

Lakshman *(annoyed)*. So what is it you want?

Mandodari. You see this dead body here in the doorway?

Lakshman. I do. But I don't know what you want me to do with it.

Mandodari. I carried him in my womb and gave him birth long ago.

Lakshman. Which of your children is this, you poor woman?

Mandodari. He did not die on the field with the others.

Lakshman. Why not? Where did he die, then? Where was he when your City was destroyed?

Mandodari. His father sent him away, to perform a sacrifice which he hoped would save us, but which has brought us only deeper ruin.

Lakshman (*startled*). What are you saying? Where did Ravana send him?

Mandodari. To the cave beside the sea; to the secret altar on Lanka's eastern shore. Vibheeshana went along with him, to bless him and preside over his rites.

Lakshman. Vibheeshana, Ravana's brother? The one who chose virtue over evil?

Mandodari. The very same. And what virtue he chose.

*Lakshman ,fearing a confrontation with the desperate **Mandodari**, hides his involvement with **Indrajit's** death.*

Lakshman (*turned away, to himself*). The great Queen Mandodari, falling to the floor and clutching my knees like a drowning woman at sea – I never thought I would see her like this. Her grief has unhinged her; she's clearly out of her senses. I killed Indrajit fairly, as a man slays an enemy in war. But if she discovers my role in his death, she may attack me; and I have no wish to pollute myself by killing a woman in a sacred place.

(*To **Mandodari***) Who killed him? What fate did he meet with?

Mandodari. Who else could it be? Vibheeshana, who now sits among my husband's killers. He either killed my son himself, or aided others in doing so.

Lakshman. Vibheeshana chose good over evil, when he decided not to aid your husband in his war against Rama. But to betray one's own blood... I admit, I did not expect one so tender-hearted to be capable of such cruelty.

Mandodari. He knew we were doomed, and turned his back on us to seek better fortune with the enemy.

Lakshman. But how come the body is here? Who brought him?

Mandodari. This woman. She found him, there in the sacred cave.

Lakshman. Was she out looking for him, or engaged at some other task?

Mandodari. I had sent her to fetch holy water, for me to perform last rites for Sita.

Lakshman. It looks as if he was surprised, ambushed while trying to perform his sacred rite.

Mandodari. Yes, betrayed by that man who now sits honoured among you; who claims virtue, yet hacked away at his own nephew's flesh.

Lakshman. Poor woman. Your husband and your people may have been my enemies; but no one deserves to suffer as you have.

Mandodari. I am glad to hear you say so. But hear the reason why I fall at your feet. You have lived by the side of God. You have learned divine wisdom. If your judgement is that what I have suffered is just, I shall be content. But if you feel the opposite, you must become the instrument of revenge upon the man who has violated the bonds of blood.

We Lankans may have fought on the side of wrong against right, we may have been blind fools to support Ravana until the end. But God is wise, and knows right from wrong. And you who have lived beside Him, should know the same. If you now corrupt this, if you judge unfairly, then not even God can be trusted to be fair, and nothing in this Universe is safe. Be my judge, Lakshman, judge between me and my husband's traitorous brother.

Lakshman , visibly uncomfortable, tries to turn away.

Mandodari. Where are you slinking off to, trying to avoid your miserable suppliant? It seems I shall achieve nothing, not even with those who call themselves righteous. O, why do we mortals toil away at so many branches of knowledge and wisdom, but when it comes to persuasion, we make no special effort by laying out money so that sometimes, we might be able to persuade people to do what we want? All this talk of virtue and the good, but what it really comes down to in the end is bribery, base greed.

Listen to me then. My City may be destroyed, but I'm sure I can still find something to give you! You can have all these women here if you like, for yourself and your masters to enjoy! *(She indicates the rakshasis of the Chorus).* O, I wish I had a voice in my arms and hands and hair, in the feet on which I walk, whether by the artifice of men or by the blessing of God, so they could all weep together and clasp your knees, urging arguments of every kind.

Please, dear Prince, Light of the World, be persuaded, give this poor woman your avenging hand. She may be only an asuri, she may be on the wrong side, she may be worthless, but even so. For it is the mark of a good man to serve justice, and never fail to treat bad men badly, even if the people they have wronged are your enemies.

Chorus. Isn't it strange? In war, it seems so clear who is on which side, who is right and who is wrong, who is enemy and who is friend. It all seems so justified. And yet, grief and necessity turn friends into the bitterest enemies, and make enemies into friends.

Lakshman *(to himself)*. Poor woman. I do pity her, and Vibheeshana did betray his brother in joining our side. But he turned from the side of Evil to the side of Good; all of us who follow Rama believe that. And I was there myself, helping Vibheeshana slay his nephew to ensure the victory of Right over Wrong. I could hardly condemn him now. But I also have no wish to turn away a grieving mother.

(To **Mandodari**). Mandodari, I feel for you and your grief, and I agree that your brother-in-law betrayed you. But think the situation over. The troops regard Vibheeshana as their friend, and your boy as their enemy. If you love him, that is a private matter and none of their concern. I want to help you – if I can find some way for you to get what you want and for me to avoid appearing ungrateful to my people's allies. I could prove quick to help you – or slow, if my assistance will lead my people (or heaven forbid, my brother) to think ill of me.

Mandodari. Ha! No man is free. Either he is a slave to money or fortune, or his honour, the opinion of the common mob, prevents him from following his own judgement. But do not worry for your reputation: I will protect you. If I plot some evil against my husband's brother, your conscience is clear; you have no share in my sins.

Do only this for me: if, when Vibheeshana suffers what he must suffer, and some disturbance arises among your people and they try to come to his aid, stop it without appearing to do so, for my sake. As for the rest – have no fear – I shall see that all turns out well, and the sin shall be all mine.

Lakshman. But how? What will you do? Will you take a sword to Vibheeshana's throat, old woman that you are? Or do you plan to poison him somehow? Who will help you? There's no one here except this old rakshasi even feebler than you are.

Mandodari. You men may not take notice of us, but there are many women still hiding within the ruined walls of Lanka.

Lakshman. You mean the prisoners, those over whom Vibheeshana is soon to be crowned King?

Mandodari. With their help, I shall take vengeance on the betrayer of my son and of my house.

Lakshman. And how will women be able to overcome men?

Mandodari. Women in numbers are formidable enough; and we rakshasis know more tricks than you give us credit for.

Lakshman. I have yet to see women beat men at war.

Mandodari. So be it. Let's stop this argument, shall we? Please give this woman (*indicates her attendant*) safe conduct through the army. (*To attendant*) When you reach Vibheeshana, say, "Mandodari, former Queen of Lanka, is calling you on a matter that concerns you no less than herself." (*To Lakshman*) O Prince, please give me a little more time to perform last rites for Sita. Let my daughter and my son be burned side by side, on the same pyre together.

Lakshman. It shall be so. Do understand, woman, that this is highly unusual; and if Rama had allowed us to return to Ayodhya straightaway, if he had not doubted Sita's purity so gravely, I would never have allowed this request of yours. I hope that things turn out well for you; but I have no wish to hear any more of your evil plans.

Lakshman goes out.

Act IV: Vengeance

Chapter Summary

Here, Lankan Women reaches its peak of violence, following Euripides into horror and bloodshed. Mandodari, enraged by the loss of her children and her husband, herself blinded by rage, tricks and blinds Vibheeshana in retaliation for his betrayal of her family during the war. Like Hecuba, and like Achilles, Mandodari crosses a moral event horizon into madness.

My source text describes the war of Lanka as far cleaner and less horrifying than Lankan Women does. There is no plunder, no enslavement, no misbehaviour, not even murder as such. Everyone who makes war on Lanka is virtuous and pure.

I don't think Euripides would agree with Valmiki's description. And, her husband and her son killed in front of her, her daughter taken away, I don't think Mandodari would, either.

Chorus (*one rakshasi raises her voice, alone*). O Lanka, my City, no longer will you be called happy, no longer will you be called blessed by Heaven! An army of bears and monkeys, led by a God Himself, surrounds you; and by the bow and the spear they have destroyed you.

Shorn you are of your crown of towers, fire blackens you. O unhappy City, I shall tread your streets no longer. Hear my story, o ruined City, one woman's story lost to time.

It was at midnight that my doom began. Sleep spread over the City; my husband had ceased from his chanting and his prayer and was lying in the bedroom, his bow hanging on the wall. We no longer watched for the tread of monkeys on our walls; for we thought our army victorious, the two Princes slain.

I was arranging my hair in the cap that binds it up, gazing down my golden mirror, about to fall on my coverlet. But a shout rang up through the city, and all along Lanka's streets this was the cry: "O army of God, when o when will you drive Ravana from his citadel, make him pay for his evil? When o when will you destroy this City of Darkness by the Powers of the Light?"

And I left my bed and my home, clad in no more than a single robe, and crouched – uselessly, now! – at Lord Shiva's temple. I saw my husband dead, and was led off, out of the City, to the shore of the salt sea. And when I looked back at my City, overrun and sacked, I fainted in my grief, and laid my curses upon them all.

Vibheeshana arrives at the ruined hermitage with two armed attendants.

Vibheeshana. O Ravana, dearest brother, and Mandodari, dearest sister, I weep for Lanka, for you, for your daughter who has just been killed. Truly, there is nothing in which we may find security: not in good reputation, not in prosperity, not in friends and family. For even the most prosperous of men, which Ravana surely was, can fall upon hard times; and then his friends and family fall with him, and his reputation ends in the dust.

So many tears I have wept for Lanka, and when I still lived within its walls, so many sacrifices did I bring, to try and win back the favour of the gods. And it was all for nothing. Sometimes, I wonder if the gods do not simply mix everything together in a topsy-turvy muddle, good and bad and sense and nonsense, just to cause confusion, just to make us worship them out of ignorance. But what's the point of lamenting? Instead, we should try to make the best of whatever situation we're in.

By the way, Mandodari, please forgive my late arrival. I should have been there to comfort you in your grief over Sita. But I was away in the City; you see, Rama intends for me to rule over Lanka temporarily, just to get things back in order you understand, until Meghanada comes of age. I was making a survey of repairs to be done around the City when I met your attendant in the street, and came here straightaway.

Mandodari. I am ashamed to look you in the face, Vibheeshana, so abject is my situation. You lived with me, you always saw me as Ravana's queen; showing myself to you like this makes me want to sink into the ground and disappear with shame. So if I can't bring myself to look you straight in the eye, dear brother, please do not interpret it as ill-feeling towards you. It's only my shame and grief that makes me act like this.

Vibheeshana. And no wonder! But... what do you want of me? Why have you sent for me from the City? I'm a busy man now, and there does not seem to be any immediate danger to you here.

Mandodari. I have some private business, concerning Sita and myself. Something for your ears only. Please come with me into the inner room, and instruct your attendants to remain outside the hermitage.

Vibheeshana (to his *attendants*). Off with you! I'm perfectly safe here. Mandodari is family, and the army is friendly towards me.

The attendants go out.

Vibheeshana (to *Mandodari*). But you must let me know how I, in my good fortune, can help you in your distress. I am at your disposal.

Mandodari. First of all, since you mentioned him – is Meghanada safe? I had heard you were to accompany him to his sacred rite at the seashore. I shall ask you the rest later; this is most important to me.

Vibheeshana. Certainly, he is very well. He is kept safe at the altar, away from the fighting and the army. Whatever your misfortune elsewhere, my dear sister, in your son you have great hope left.

Mandodari. O dearest brother, such wonderful words you speak! Just what I expected you to say.

Vibheeshana. Very well, then. What other thing did you want to see me about?

Mandodari. Meghanada... has he mentioned me at all? Does he miss me?

Vibheeshana. He does. In fact, I had to stop him from coming here with me! For his own safety, I could not allow it; Rama's army knows me, but the folk of Kishkindha may easily mistake Meghanada for an enemy. I couldn't risk him being hurt.

Mandodari. And have you spoken with Rama about Meghanada's accession to the throne of Lanka once he comes of age? He is the rightful heir, after all, and Ravana's sins do not cling to him.

Vibheeshana. Certainly, it's all been arranged. Rama and I both love and value your son. I will gladly step aside when the time comes.

Mandodari. Of course. I expected no less of you. You've always had a reputation for virtue that was well-deserved, brother. You know better than to covet what belongs to your neighbour.

Vibheeshana. Naturally. I'd much rather enjoy what I have at present. Nothing but misery comes from envy.

Mandodari. Do you know what I want to say to you, Vibheeshana?

Vibheeshana. I do not. How can I? I'm waiting for you to tell me.

Mandodari. When Ravana took Sita, her jewels and ornaments fell from the sky as he flew. We women have gone in secret to find them, and I have them in keeping here in the inner room. When she was still with me, Sita would not wear them anymore. Please take them to Rama. They belong to his house by right, his to sell or to melt down; and they might soften his heart towards my daughter's memory.

Vibheeshana. That is what you called me here for?

Mandodari. Yes; I want you alone to do it, because you are such a pious man. I would not trust any other with my poor daughter's gold. But first, come inside and inspect the ornaments, so you may see with your own eyes that they are all complete.

Vibheeshana. Where have you hidden them? This is an ascetic's house, and a ruined one at that.

Mandodari. We keep it safe, here with the other plunder.

Vibheeshana. What plunder? All of Lanka's wealth is outside among the tents of the army, waiting to be taken to Ayodhya and Kishkindha.

Mandodari. Only women stayed here; so the men dared not enter.

Vibheeshana (*suspicious, peering into the dark entrance of the inner rooms*). Is everything quite safe in there? Are there no men?

Mandodari. No men are there of either Lanka or India, only us women. But come quickly – I'm sure your Prince will soon want to be on his way, and you are doubtless eager to set about on your regency of Lanka.

Vibheeshana and Mandodari enter the inner room. Mandodari closes the door behind them, a beautifully carved door of thin tropical wood.

Chorus. You have not yet paid the price, but perhaps you will. Like a man who has fallen into the sea with no harbour in sight, you will fall from your good fortune and lose your life. For where justice is violated, doom must follow.

Your hopes of the throne of Lanka will cheat you, for they will lead you to death; and it is not a warrior's hand by which you will fall.

Vibheeshana (*from inside*). Help me! I'm being blinded, my eyes are put out!

Chorus. Did you hear anything, friends? Some sort of wailing, perhaps?

Vibheeshana (*muffled*). Please, anyone, help me! This is butchery, why is no one listening to me?

Chorus. Oh dear friends, they're doing unheard of horrors in the inner rooms. Better to stay out here.

Vibheeshana (*muffled*). You demons, you won't escape! I'll burn this whole miserable City down if I have to!

Chorus. Do you think we should rush in there? This is the moment we've been waiting for; this is the moment for us women of Lanka to stand shoulder to shoulder with Mandodari and have our revenge on the traitor of our people.

Mandodari comes out of the inner room.

Mandodari (*triumphant*). Flail away, dear brother, tear out the door, burn whatever you want. Set alight all of Lanka, Vibheeshana; you will never put light back into your ruined eyes.

Chorus. Have you really done it? Have you really mastered your treacherous brother-in-law and destroyed him?

Mandodari. In a moment you'll see him coming out of that room, a blind man crawling on the floor like a worm. He has paid me the just penalty, and he has paid it in blood. But look, here he comes now; I'll quickly move out of his way. Stay away from him, women; let him rage all by himself.

Vibheeshana crawls out on all fours, his face a ruinous mess of blood, two red streams of liquid flesh where his eyes should be.

Vibheeshana. Where can I go? Where can I run to? Where will I find safe haven? If only I could get my hands on those women – where are you, you demons! I know you haven't gone far, I can hear you! A curse on all of them. What corner are they cowering in, beasts that they are?

O God of the Sun, have mercy on me! Restore light to my eyes, so I can take the vengeance I deserve! Quiet – I hear the stealthy movement of women here. Where should I rush to, to glut myself with their flesh and bones, feast on those savage beasts, tear them limb from limb like a wolf? How could Fate and Justice let this happen to me? After a lifetime of prayer and virtue and meditation, am I to end torn apart on the hillside by accursed Bacchantes, am I to die as prey to wild beasts?

How shall I live, without my eyes, without my name? Where can I ever find rest?

Chorus. You evil man. Yes, what has been done to you is terrible. But a man who has done shameful things, a man who has betrayed his own blood – he deserves to pay a terrible price. You speak of prayer, of virtue – but where was your virtue when you ran straight to our enemy in the midst of a war, where was your virtue when you betrayed your own nephew to be hacked to pieces like a beast?

Vibheeshana (*raising his voice, desperate*). Help me! Anyone! Hey you, men of Kishkindha, aren't you friends of mine? Where are you, why won't you help me? For heaven's sake, please come, please listen!

(*Quieter*) Does anyone hear me at all? Will no one come to help me? Will you all just leave me here, one more destroyed rakshasa among so many others?

Chorus. Poor wretched thing. You do suffer greatly, and what happened to you, while just, was also cruel. Take our advice. When someone suffers misfortunes too heavy to bear, he can be forgiven if he rids himself of his own life.

Act V - Farewell

Chapter Summary

Lakshman and Mandodari sit in judgement over Vibheeshana and receive tragic oracles from him, as their counterparts in Euripides did from Polymestor. Finally, abandoning Euripides, Sita reappears on the scene; for unlike Polyxena, Sita did not die in her fire.

But not even Sita is granted a happy farewell: she appears on an empty stage, her mother and her people all gone, her city empty. Thus Lankan Women ends in a quiet sunset.

Lakshman enters.

Lakshman. I heard shouting. In fact, you women were so loud that it caused quite an uproar around the army. If we hadn't been sure that Ravana was dead and burned and Lanka defeated, this din would have caused considerable alarm.

Vibheeshana. Is that Lakshman's voice I hear? O dearest friend, someone has come to save me at last! Do you see what I suffer at the hands of these demons?

Lakshman (*with a start*). Great heavens, Vibheeshana, who has done this to you? What happened to your face, your eyes? Whoever he was, he must have felt great anger.

Vibheeshana. It was Mandodari who destroyed me, together with these terrible women here – no, not destroyed me, but worse.

Lakshman. What are you saying? (*to Mandodari*) Did you really do this? It seems so... excessive, for a Queen to have done to a man.

Vibheeshana. Who are you talking to? Is she there, is she there, that terrible demoness? Tell me, let me know where she is! Even without eyes I will tear her flesh from her bones, with my teeth if I have to! I'll tear her to pieces!

Lakshman (*catching hold of him*). Hey! What's the matter with you?

Vibheeshana (*shaking*). Let me go! Please let me go, let me attack her!

Lakshman. Control yourself! Empty your heart of its savagery and state your case, so that I can hear each of you and for a fair judgement about why you have suffered this treatment.

Vibheeshana. I shall do so gladly. There was a son of Ravana, Meghanada, Mandodari's child, the youngest but the bravest of all. When Lanka's destruction seemed certain, he went down to our sacred cave by the eastern shore of the sea to bring a sacrifice, hoping to turn the

tide. I accompanied him there as priest; and I led him into an ambush, giving him up for the forces of Rama to defeat.

But hear why I did it. In my heart, I had long been convinced of Ravana's evil. His corruption spread further and further and would have plunged the whole world into darkness, had he been allowed to continue on his path. In Rama I recognized the Light of the World, the Deliverance of the Universe from evil and from suffering. How could I not support his cause, your cause, Lakshman? And if Meghanada had been allowed to complete his ritual, untold power would have been his.

I, Vibheeshana, have brought victory to you, brought victory to God! Yes, it came at the cost of this young prince's life; but surely, for the triumph of Good over Evil, such a price is not too high? And you know all this, Lakshman, you know it as well as I do; for were you not there with me, in the cave? Did you not lie in wait at my command, in the place of which I had told you?

But Mandodari found out about her son's fate. If only that wretched old rakshasi servant had never gone down there to find what she wasn't supposed to see! Then this woman, this demoness, called me here on some false pretext, pretending to a pious worry for her daughter's ornaments and Rama's rights to them.

She led me into the inner room on my own, and what a fool I was to trust her, to think that my sister Mandodari would never hurt me! In that room was a couch, and she invited me to sit while she fetched the jewels. But when I did so, other women came, and girls, too. They took my weapons from me, they held my hands, my head, my feet, clinging on like octopuses; and then this woman, my sister, undid the clasp that held her cloak and stabbed at the pupils of my eyes, again and again, until all that was left of them was a mess of blood. Then they all ran away and hid, cowardly beasts that they are, knowing I couldn't see them.

I have suffered all this to further your interests, Lakshman, to further the interests of Rama! I am your ally, your fellow fighter, we fought Meghanada side by side! You owe me loyalty! As for these women: neither the earth nor the sea has ever produced a race of monsters quite like them. Perhaps Rama was right to drive Sita into the flames, if this is what womankind is like.

Chorus. How dare you accuse us, you traitor! You turn your back on your own people and then call us monsters. In all your life you have never had so much as a grain of Sita's virtue. And you, Lakshman... what is he saying? Were you involved in this as well?

Lakshman. Be silent, Vibheeshana. You may have been an ally in this war, but I came here only following my Divine brother. You are no concern of mine.

Mandodari. Lakshman, the tongue should never have more influence among men than deeds. If a man has acted wisely, his words will have the ring of truth; but false actions can result only in false words. And my brother's words ring false indeed.

(To *Vibheeshana*) So, you killed my son for the sake of God, did you? To ensure Good would be Victorious over Evil? In the first place, you monstrous wretch, these Princes of Ayodhya are men; and men would never become friends with rakshasas. It would be impossible. Or

did you think the folk of Ayodhya would accept one of our kind? They never even came to your aid while you were being blinded in my inner room, these friends of yours.

And besides, if you truly believed that Rama is the Supreme God Himself, why would he need Meghanada to die? Surely the Supreme God, Maintainer of the Universe, would not be threatened by a simple fire ritual carried out by a boy in a cave? Unless it was the throne of Lanka that killed my son – your hope that the Prince of Ayodhya, after his victory, would install you his ally here in Lanka to rule.

For tell me this. How was it that when Ravana was still triumphant, when our City still prospered, before there was any inkling of war on our clear horizon, you did not destroy that altar, or take Meghanada to Ayodhya yourself as a hostage, to present to this Rama along with your worship? If you truly only wanted to do your God a favour – you lived with us, you had him in your house, you were his tutor. But when we were no longer in the light, when Lanka was about to fall and Ravana was weakened and safely out of your way – that is when you chose to run to our enemies, that is when you killed my son.

And now let me tell you something else which makes it plain how vile you are. If you were truly a friend to these Princes, if you truly wanted only their good above your own, you would refuse the Kingship of Lanka which they have offered you, and become their servant instead. Become a pious ascetic, as you say you are, and let men from Ayodhya rule our City, or monkeys from Kishkindha. But you cannot bear the thought.

And another thing. If you had stood by us, stood by Meghanada's side like you ought to have done, you might have died indeed along with all the others; but you would have won for yourself a name for virtue and goodness. For in bad times, those who continue to show friendship are regarded by all men as good. If you truly cared about the Good, as you say, you would have chosen death, rather than betrayal.

But as things stand now, you have no friends at all, Vibheeshana. This man here is not your friend. Whether or not he helped you kill my son – he might well have done, for he is an enemy champion – he disavows you. The folk of Kishkindha never came to your aid. Any benefit you might have had from the Kingship of Lanka is gone, for no one will respect a traitor.

What happened to you, my brother? What madness made you betray not only us, but yourself as well? You led a life steeped in wisdom and virtue; and now you are reduced to this.

(To **Lakshman**) I tell you, Lakshman, if you help him, you will be seen as a bad man. Across all the world, men will say that you take pleasure in bad men because you are like them yourself. But I shall not speak ill of you. I shall reserve my judgement. You may yet judge fairly.

Chorus. Splendid! It is true indeed, that a good cause gives rise to truthful words.

Lakshman. I find it a troublesome task to pronounce judgement in so sordid a case, and one that does not involve my own people. I would rather not be involved at all. But I am here, I am called upon to judge; and as a Prince and a warrior, it is my duty to punish evil and uphold righteousness.

(To **Vibheeshana**) To be plain with you, I do not believe it was piety that drove you to betray your own people. It was base fear, and perhaps greed. You are merely using whatever arguments you can think of to convince me. Mandodari is right. Rakshasas are not men. Perhaps among your people, it is a light matter to kill a blood relative. But among us men, it is a shameful act. How can I escape criticism if I judge you innocent? It is impossible. As for your sufferings: since you had the hardiness to commit treason, you should be able to bear the punishment.

Vibheeshana. Am I to be betrayed then? Am I to accept humiliation from women?

Mandodari. Isn't it just? What you have done was evil, Vibheeshana.

(**Vibheeshana** cries out in pain)

Mandodari. Are you in pain? What of it? Don't you think I feel pain, for my boy, for my daughter, for my husband and my City, all of whom you betrayed?

Vibheeshana. You are a demon. You rejoice in brutality. You will stop at nothing.

Mandodari. And why shouldn't I rejoice, as I take vengeance for the wrongs that were done to me?

Vibheeshana. Do you think you will all escape? You, Lakshman, do you think you will live out your days happily in Ayodhya? I have sat in penance a long time, and I once possessed prophetic powers. Tragedy awaits you all. You, Lakshman, will die in the river, your brother beside you –

Lakshman. You there, are you mad? Are you in love with suffering?

Vibheeshana. Kill me if you like. Your Fate awaits you, whatever you do to me.

Lakshman (to his *attendants*) Drag him off! Use force.

Vibheeshana. Does it give you pain to hear me, dear friend?

Lakshman (to his *attendants*). Stop him talking!

Vibheeshana (*smiling*). Yes, gag me. I have said my say.

Lakshman (to his *attendants*). Drag him away, I don't care where to, throw him in the sea if you like! This is unendurable.

Vibheeshana is dragged off.

Lakshman (to **Mandodari**). And you, poor woman, go and perform last rites for both your children.

*Mandodari goes out. Only the **Chorus** is left now.*

Chorus. Look, the army is leaving, they are breaking up their tents. On to the stony bridge, my friends; we are captives, after all – it is time to join our masters, to embark on a life of slavery or worse.

Farewell, fair Lanka. Necessity is harsh.

*The **Chorus** goes out. After they have left, **Sita** approaches and stands in front of the stage building, alone. She stares off into the distance at Lanka.*

Sita. One last look my husband has granted me, one last look upon the City in which I was first a captive, then a daughter, and finally a sacrifice. O, I went into the fire; and I went proudly, looking straight in the eyes of my husband and his brother and all of his friends, daring them to find in me a trace of the pollution which he said I carried. I saw how they all cringed and wept before me, averting their eyes in shame, all those great warriors with their great honour.

Only the fire knew my purity. It would not burn me, would not hurt me. Instead, it shielded me, protected me from the eyes of the men. As I entered the pyre, the flames rose up and engulfed me, and that was all any of them saw. And I sat at the heart of that flame, safe and cared for. Once the fire was extinguished, no charred bones of mine did the men find; for the god of the fire had whisked me away, made me invisible to their stares.

I was revealed only once my husband's anger cooled – and how they all cheered when they found me still alive! How they cheered not for my sake, but for the sake of their own conscience. And my husband graciously took me back, said he never meant any of it, said he drove me into the fire only to preserve his honour in the eyes of his army and not from any ill-feeling towards me. Such tears he wept, and so honourable he looked.

And now one last look my husband has granted me, just before we embark upon his virtuous reign in Ayodhya. One last look upon my mother's face – but I can find her no longer.

***Sita** goes out. The stage stands empty in the setting sun.*

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